Lee-Ann Vidal-Covas | PhD

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Summary

Language Scientist combining 10+ years of linguistics research with industry experience in AI training & model evaluation, voice-content production, and technology consulting. I specialize in analyzing conversational language data, and the evaluation & testing of ML and language models. I build analysis pipelines & scripts to analyze data, draw insights, and identify improvement opportunities. My linguistics training helps me see where meaning gets ambiguous and judge edge cases carefully. I follow QA processes closely, document issues clearly, and communicate findings to technical and non-technical audiences. Ph.D. in Linguistics; native bilingual speaker of English & Spanish.

Experience

Micro1 Inc

2026 – Present **AI Training Expert**

- Tested evaluation tasks & adversarial prompts against live large language model outputs across multiple trials, analyzing model behavior until each task reliably exposed a genuine failure mode.
- Designed Q&A evaluation tasks for frontier LLMs, each anchored to one indisputable, source-verifiable fact.
- Screened tasks for ambiguity, bias-sensitive framing & time-stability, and documented quote-supported justifications in a multi-stage QA workflow (review, verification, sign-off).

Cogito Corporation (now part of Verint)

2022 – 2023 **Data Annotator | Machine Learning Annotation**

- Annotated real-world conversational audio for ML models, keeping labels consistent as guidelines changed.
- Tested pre-trained ML models via prompt engineering & gave calibration feedback that improved accuracy.
- Handled unique data requests & suggested workflow improvements, cutting annotation turnaround time.

Boston University

2018 – 2025 **Doctoral Researcher | Project & Lab Manager**

- Formalized variation in Spanish-English conversational speech into a rule-based annotation scheme with explicit coding criteria & regex patterns, annotation guidelines, & QA protocols for a multi-year project.
- Built reproducible R pipelines, version-controlled on Git/GitHub, to clean, validate, & analyze speech data with mixed-effects regression models, and presented insights to stakeholders & at international conferences.
- Designed & ran an online experiment on Spanish word order (Qualtrics, Prolific); wrote design documents and analyzed results with linear & logistic mixed-effects models in R.
- Automated dataset updates with reusable scripts (~15 hours/week saved) & trained 10+ student researchers.

Communications On Hold

2018 – Present **Technology Consultant**

- Built & deployed the company website (Hugo, GitHub, Netlify CI/CD) with a custom audio library; IT support (software, email, domains) & Spanish audio production.

2007 – 2017 **Operations & Production Manager**

- Led scriptwriting & production teams for custom voice content (on-hold messaging, IVR & call-routing prompts, radio commercials), owning final sign-off, client accounts & invoicing automation.

Education

2025 Ph.D., Linguistics, Boston University

2021 M.A., Linguistics, Boston University

2013 M.A., Hispanic Studies & Linguistics, Louisiana State University

2011 B.A., Hispanic Studies & Literatures, Louisiana State University

Skills

Data Analysis: Statistical analysis & insights, data cleaning & validation, visualization, R pipelines, scripting & workflow automation. **Model Evaluation & Testing:** LLM & ML model evaluation, failure-mode testing, conversational audio annotation, calibration feedback, prompt engineering, QA workflows. **Linguistic Data & Annotation:** Annotation schemes & coding criteria, guideline & QA protocol development, data labeling (text & audio), issue reporting, annotator training. **Communication:** Technical documentation, client & stakeholder communication, presenting to non-technical audiences. **Tech Tools:** R, Python, Bash, Git/GitHub, Jira, regex, Excel, Praat, ELAN, VSCode, LaTeX, HTML, Claude Code (custom agents & skills).
Languages: English (native), Spanish (native), Brazilian Portuguese (elementary).

Citizenship

Dual Citizenship: American & Spanish.

Research

Published in peer-reviewed venues; presented at international conferences. See Academic CV or website for full list.

Selected publications:

Erker, Daniel G. & **Vidal-Covas, Lee-Ann M.** (2024). Variation, Contact, and Change in Boston Spanish: How social meaning shapes stylistic practice and bilingual optimization. *Studies in Hispanic and Lusophone Linguistics*, 17(2), 223–249.

Vidal-Covas, Lee-Ann M. (2023). ¿Va primero el verbo? or ¿El sujeto va primero?: Subject-verb order in Latin American Spanish. *Proceedings of the Linguistic Society of America*, 8(1), Article 5542.

Erker, Daniel G. & **Vidal-Covas, Lee-Ann M.** (2022). What we say when we say nothing at all: Clues to contact-induced language change in Spanish conversational pause-fillers. *Estudios del Observatorio / Observatorio Studies*, 80.

Dionne, Danielle & **Vidal-Covas, Lee-Ann M.** (Eds.) (2021). Proceedings of the 45th Annual Boston University Conference on Language Development. Somerville, MA, Cascadilla Press.

References

Available upon request.